

Editorial

I Got Your Mobile Number!

WOULD YOU LIKE your mobile number listed in a public directory?

Late August, the Telecom Regulatory Authority of India (TRAI) released a consultation paper asking cellular service providers to publish directories of their users' mobile numbers, just like landline directories that MTNL and BSNL publish.

Publishing a directory is a mandatory clause of an Indian cellular service provider's license agreement, but service providers have consistently avoided doing so, citing customer disinterest and privacy issues. Insiders say the real reason the companies do not want to publish a mobile directory is to avoid stretching their already-tight budgets on publishing a behemoth.

Whatever the reason, a publicly available cellular directory in India is invitation to trouble—and not just because telemarketers would take advantage of the millions of mobile numbers listed. The primary cause of individual complaints would be the lack of a system to address grievances.

It is no secret that credit card companies, insurance companies, and now even pubs and political parties routinely use mobile messaging to garner new consumers, or votes. The trouble is, who will address an individual's complaint if he or she receives spam SMSes, or persistent, unsolicited calls, or, horror of horrors—extortion calls?

The TRAI is, after all, a regulatory body—it does not have the teeth to punish offenders.

The US has a national *Do Not Call Registry*, which is a safeguard against telemarketers misusing publicly available telephone numbers. If a telemarketer calls up a number on the register, he is liable to pay a fine of \$11,000 per individual. The fine is imposed swiftly, and the individual feels vindicated.

WYTY.com, also based in the US, has set up an opt-in online mobile directory. You can register on the Web site, and list your number. The biggest safeguard here is that you need to specify a name to retrieve a number. This means that only those who know your name—your friends, relatives and business acquaintances—will be able to access your number.

In India, once again, this idea would elicit little response. Most mobile users are not Net savvy. Besides,



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telemarketers will always find a way to reach you.

The TRAI, meanwhile, had asked cellular operators to comment on the directory idea by September 10. No one did.

They have now extended the response deadline to September 30. Is the TRAI expecting a miracle?

We, then, come full circle, back to the same question: would you like your mobile number listed in a public directory?

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